

deceit than his enemies. This adds spice to the stories. The devil with the best tunes is Hamza's foster brother Amar, who begins stealing shortly after his birth, his first trophy being the ring he sucks off the king's finger. As a child he torments his teacher endlessly, booby-trapping his bed with thousands of needles. Amar has the licence of the court jester as well as considerable power. He and Hamza also have an ally at court—a minister as wise as Vidura who can foresee the future. Destiny is important to Hamza, as is the supernatural. The characters of these stories have all the major faults and merits of humankind but the *dastaan* imagination cannot be contained within the narrow pot of realism.

Hamza's beloved, the beautiful princess Mehr-Nigar has a tough time. Her fiancé seems more interested in his next adventure than his betrothed. She weeps tears of blood as Hamza sets out on quest after quest. The Adventures have for centuries been truly 'world literature', recounted in many languages over Africa and Asia. Hamza's character is loosely based on an uncle of Prophet Mohammad, but the *dastaan* is clearly fiction, not history. It is a credit to the literary genius of India that the *dastaan* of Amir Hamza, which the Emperor Akbar must have heard in Persian, reached its zenith here in Urdu, an Indian language.

Musharraf Ali Farooqi, who is settled in the United States, realised that his own generation was fast losing the knowledge of literary Urdu his forefathers had. Fearing that the Adventures would be lost in obscurity after a 1,000-year history in South Asia, he balanced three dictionaries on his knees simultaneously, and set about this translation. His source was a respected 19th-century printed version of the *dastaan* in Urdu. As the *dastaan* is proverbially long, it was a formidable task. His heroic effort has been rewarded in a work which gives Hamza a place in American literature too. It is indeed a wonderful book replete with poetry, elegant turns of phrase, choice abuses, jokes, drama and suspense. Even in English, the battle scenes remind one of a Meer Anis *marsia*, while the lovers are as impulsive as Romeo and Juliet. Quite simply, this *dastaan* in any language is an antidote to the cares of this world. ■



The History of Forgetting

Visions of the legendary lost past haunt a fourteenth-generation clone, the protagonist of this sci-fi novel, turning her into a human



GENERATION 14
by PRIYA SARUKKAI CHABRIA
Penguin-Zubaan
Price: Rs 295
Pages: 284

■ **By Bunny Suraiya**

The author of *Generation 14* is both a novelist and a poet, and that's the trouble. The book doesn't know what to be—a sci-fi story or a collection of mythic poetic tales. Some of the poetic imagery is very good: "*Hissing like tears the town burns down, hissing like curses we speed through the ruins, hissing with grief the survivors lie crumpled.*" Parts of the sci-fi narrative are gripping, but the jumping back and forth between the two formats eventually exhausts the reader's patience.

The chief protagonist is a 14th-generation clone, Clone 14/54/G, not a name conducive to reader-empathy, unlike R2D2, which, at least when spoken aloud, sounds cute. Clone 14/54/G lives in a Global Community which consists of a rigorously categorised hierarchy—Originals or humans (who have life), Firehearts or poets (who have presence), Superior Zombies (who have existence) and Clones (who have a period of being, known as actuality). The problems begin when Clone 14/54/G starts having dreams, or "visitations", as she calls them, of people and events

that took place not just centuries but millennia earlier. These dreams, the beginnings of memory, are the first signs that she is mutating into a human.

The allegory is clear enough. Global Community is our own increasingly soulless, materialistic society, with the four classifications of the social hierarchy parodying India's caste system. The author's position is that it is memory which creates the human (a useful insight, though not original; it was George Orwell who introduced us to the concept of double-think and continual historical revisionism as tools of mastery), and which is sought to be suppressed by those who want to make robotic slaves of us. Clone 14/54/G is a danger to the powers that be. She assumes the role of the stylus of history, straining to see, beyond the antiseptic present, the long-repressed glimpses of the glory that was ancient Ind. Courtesans, emperors, warriors, birds and beasts speak their narratives through her—an unwitting medium for the legendary lost past.

The poetic narratives could have formed a separate book, instead of being jumbled into the sci-fi story with its clinical prose and an ending derivative of P.D. James's *The Children of Men*. Priya Sarukkai Chabria has missed an opportunity to write two interesting books instead of one confused composite. The muddling up of Chapters 30 to 38 through faulty pagination doesn't help. ■